medical units on an ad-hoc basis, to make sure that our veterans were looked after in the best possible manner. It took a year or so to procure equipment like X-ray machines and other diagnostic apparatus for the ECHS clinics spread all over the country. I held a meeting in Delhi with the managing directors and chief executive officers of empanelled private hospitals, dental and diagnostic centres to discuss the aim and scope of the ECHS. The meeting was attended by eminent doctors such as Dr Naresh Trehan and Dr S. Khanna. Measures to streamline the timely clearance of bills of the hospitals were discussed and I also appealed to the medical fraternity not to exploit the veterans and the ECHS. In the long run it would definitely prove to be a win-win for all the stakeholders.

Orders were issued by my adjutant general, Lieutenant General A.S. Jamwal, that it would be the responsibility of the nearest army station HQ to take care of all the funeral arrangements and related expenses whenever any veteran passed away. This was to facilitate dignified and befitting funerals and last rites of veterans. I was happy to see that this measure was very well received by the rank and file and particularly by the families, for whom it became a matter of pride and a source of comfort.

From the point of view of morale and motivation, judicious, equitable and timely grant of leave is a very important function of command. Some leaders are stingy about leave and some go to the extent of clamping down on it before an important event to make sure that everyone is present. Consequently there are bound to be some demotivated soldiers around, and things that could go wrong often did. As a leader, leave was never an issue with me. If an individual had a genuine personal problem he was given leave. The only thing that I have always insisted upon is that whoever goes on leave must hand over his charge properly to the next in command and not leave behind an orphan organization. Besides, I felt that there was a huge need for enhancing the leave travel concessions for all ranks, particularly for those serving in operational areas and along the borders. I was very happy that we were able to get the MOD's approval for the grant of a second free railway warrant annually to travel to one's hometown. We did away with the